> travellers alight, and where they buy all that they need. Were it not for them, no Muslim could travel by it.

Battuta comes to Calicut in a trading vessel. He calls it ‘one of the largest harbours in the world . . . visited by men from China, Sumatra, Ceylon, the Maldives, Yemen, and Fars [Persia], and in it gather merchants from all quarters’. His shipmates receive a rousing welcome by the ruling Zamorin, with drums, trumpets and bugles, and he stays as the king’s guest.

There were so many Arab merchants in Calicut that Ma Huan ‘believed its entire population to be Muslim’.[5] There was also a strong resident community of Muslims, known as Mappilas, who spoke Malayalam (Muslims had been living here since at least the ninth century). Battuta describes the huge Chinese ships in the Calicut harbour, some with four decks, big cabins with chambers and lavatory, and able to carry a thousand men. Prominent merchants often travelled with their ‘slave girls and wives’. At this time, the Chinese controlled all the shipping to and from China, using their own giant ships. Battuta remarks, ‘There is no people in the world wealthier than the Chinese.’

A century later in 1443 CE, Abdur Razzaq visits Calicut and also reports that all men here, king and beggar alike, wear only loincloths. ‘The people of Calicut are brave seafarers,’ he writes. Their ships ‘go to Mecca, mostly carrying pepper’. ‘They venerate cows to such an extent that they rub the ashes of its dung on their foreheads’ and ‘if anyone kills a cow and is found out, that person is immediately put to death’. Razzaq also reports the prevalence of a matrilineal system with polyandry. When the king dies, ‘his sister’s son takes his place, and [the kingship] is not given to son, brother or other relative’. The king comes from a ‘tribe whose women have multiple husbands, each of whom has a specific task to perform. They divide the day and night, and each one goes to the [wife’s] quarters at a specified time. So long as [one husband] is there, no other can go in’.[6] Ibn Battuta also recognizes something of this custom in his writing, ‘The rulers in these lands transmit their sovereignty to their sister’s sons, to the exclusion of their own children.’ Even the Mappila Muslims of Malabar practised matrilineal inheritance.[7]

Afanasy Nikitin visits c. 1470 and confirms the common male attire, adding, ‘Women walk about with their heads uncovered and their breasts